ARGENTINE BLACK-AND-WHITE TEGU

Salvator merianae

1. What can it see, hear, or feel?
Its forked tongue tastes the air, its nose finds bugs under leaves, and it feels ground vibrations.

2. Where does it live — and why?
It lives in forest edges and savanna, digging deep burrows for shelter, winter rest, and eggs.

3. How does it send messages?
It hisses when cornered, puffs up its body at rivals, and males leave scent trails for females.

4. What does it do when something changes?
If threatened, it runs or stands and hisses; in cold months, it rests in its burrow without eating.

5. How does it learn?
Young tegus hatch alone and learn by trying — flicking their tongue to check new things.

6. How does it have babies?
A mother lays eggs in a burrow or termite mound and guards the nest with her own body heat.

7. What are its limits?
Without warm basking spots, it cannot digest food, and cold forces it underground for months.

8. What does this teach us?
Activity, digestion, and having babies all tie directly to temperature for this lizard.

WHY IS THIS ANIMAL HERE?

Argentine tegus live in the grasslands and forests of central South America.

Their habitat is being cleared for farming and cattle.

They also face pressure from the pet trade and road deaths.

When its habitat shrinks:

- nesting and basking sites are lost to farmland
- released pets have started invading new places like Florida
- invasions hurt native wildlife where tegus do not belong

This place is not their natural home, but it can help keep the species alive.

THINK ABOUT THIS

If your tongue could taste the air to find food, where would you point it first?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Environment shapes design.

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